PRINTABLE

Twenty questions for the table

One card per story. Cut them out, put them in a jar, and pull one at dinner, in the car, or at the end of a lesson. Each card carries a question the story leaves open — there is no answer on the back, on purpose.

Printing: A4 or Letter, actual size, background graphics on. Four cards per sheet, dashed lines are cut lines.

AESOP

The Boy Who Cried Wolf

Who believes a liar when they finally tell the truth?

Once someone has lied to you, what would it take to believe them again?

Ages 5–8 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

AESOP

The North Wind and the Sun

Which works better — pushing, or warming?

When you want someone to change what they're doing, what actually changes their mind?

Ages 5–8 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

AESOP

The Bundle of Sticks

One stick snaps. A bundle doesn't. So what exactly is the bundle?

What can your family, or your class, do together that nobody in it could do alone?

Ages 6–9 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

ZHUANGZI

The Man Who Dreamed He Was a Butterfly

How do you know you are not dreaming right now?

If you cannot tell, does it matter?

Ages 6–9 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

AN INDIAN PARABLE

The Elephant and the Six Blind Men

Six people touch the same animal. They all describe something different.

Can everybody be partly right and still be wrong?

Ages 6–9 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

HANS CHRISTIAN ANDERSEN

The Emperor's New Clothes

Everybody can see it. Nobody will say it.

Why is it so hard to say the true thing when everyone else is silent?

Ages 6–10 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

AESOP

The Fox and the Grapes

Have you ever decided you didn't want something — the exact moment you couldn't have it?

When we can't have what we want, is it better to change what we want — or to pretend we never wanted it?

Ages 6–9 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

AESOP, THE HARE

The Race Nobody Agreed On

The hare can run three times as fast as the tortoise. He still loses.

What counts as winning, and who decided where the finish line is?

Ages 6–9 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

CHINESE FOLKTALE

The Boy With the Empty Pot

The emperor gives every child a seed. Whoever grows the best plant becomes the next emperor.

Would you hand in an empty pot?

Ages 7–10 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

PLUTARCH, THESEUS

The Ship That Was Replaced

Change one plank. Then another. When is it a different ship?

What is it that makes something the same thing over time?

Ages 7–10 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

PLATO, THE REPUBLIC

The Cave

What if you had never seen anything but shadows?

Are you sure that everything you can see is everything there is?

Ages 8–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

EUBULIDES, THE SORITES

When Is a Heap Not a Heap?

Take one grain off a heap of rice. Still a heap. Keep going. So where did the heap go?

If every single step looks harmless, how does a big change ever happen?

Ages 8–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

THE BUDDHA, THE ARROW

The Arrow You Won't Pull Out

A man is shot by an arrow. Before it is pulled out, he wants to know who made it.

Which questions must be answered now, and which ones can wait?

Ages 8–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

CICERO, DAMOCLES

The Sword Above the Throne

A king offers a courtier his throne for one day. There is a sword hanging above it.

Would you take the throne if you knew exactly what came with it?

Ages 8–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

ZENO'S PARADOX

Achilles and the Tortoise

The fastest runner in Greece can never catch a tortoise. Can you find the cheat?

If there is always another half of a gap to cross first, how does anything ever arrive?

Ages 9–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

PLUTARCH, DIOGENES

Stand Out of My Sunlight

The most powerful man in the world offers a philosopher anything he wants. The philosopher asks for one small thing.

What do you actually need, and who decides what that is?

Ages 9–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

ZHUANGZI, THE FISH

How Do You Know the Fish Is Happy?

Zhuangzi says the fish are happy. His friend says: you are not a fish.

Can you ever really know what another creature is feeling?

Ages 9–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

KISA GOTAMI

A Handful of Mustard Seed

Her child has died. She asks for medicine. She is sent to find a house where nobody has died.

Does knowing that everyone grieves make grief easier, or heavier?

Ages 9–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

PLATO, THE REPUBLIC

The Ring That Made Him Invisible

What would you do if you knew nobody would ever find out?

Are you good, or are you just being watched?

Ages 9–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com

ZHUANGZI, THE TREE

The Tree Nobody Could Use

A carpenter walks past an enormous old tree and refuses to look at it.

Is it better to be useful and used up, or useless and left standing?

Ages 9–12 · little-thinker.browserstay.com